

Hackathon details

Build a game using Zed and ElevenLabs APIs, then submit a high-quality viral-style video showcasing your gameplay.

[Zed](#) is a high-performance, multiplayer code editor built from the ground up in Rust. It's fast, beautiful, and designed for the AI era — with built-in AI assistance that helps you code faster.

[ElevenLabs](#) offers state-of-the-art audio AI — text-to-speech, voice cloning, sound effects, and music generation. Use ElevenLabs' APIs to bring your game to life with dynamic audio, character voices, procedural soundscapes, or AI-generated music.

What we're looking for

We want to see smaller, more polished game experiences. Focus on quality over scope — a tight, complete experience beats an ambitious but unfinished one. Your video should showcase the gameplay clearly and demonstrate how audio enhances the player experience.

We're particularly excited about games that make us feel something — whether that's joy, tension, wonder, or nostalgia. Use ElevenLabs' audio capabilities to create atmosphere, emotion, and immersion.

Getting started

Download [Zed](#) and start building. Use Zed's AI features to help you prototype quickly, and integrate ElevenLabs APIs to add voice, sound effects, or music to your game.

Resources

- [Zed documentation](#)
- [ElevenLabs API quickstart](#)

Tag us

When posting your submission on social media, tag [@zeddotdev](#) and [@elevenlabsio](#) and use the hashtag [#ElevenHacks](#).

Scoring

- Social posts: +50 pts per platform (X, LinkedIn, Instagram, TikTok)
- Placement: 1st place +400 pts, 2nd +200 pts, 3rd +150 pts
- Most Viral: +200 pts for the post with the most engagement
- Most Popular: +200 pts (community vote via emoji reacts)

Submission guide

The best demos do two things: **solve a real need** and are **genuinely entertaining**. The difference between a forgettable entry and one that wins prizes (and goes viral) comes down to a handful of decisions you make *before* you start building.

The #1 mistake

Most people spend 90% of their time on the code and rush the video at the end. Flip that. AI has made building faster than ever. Your code is table stakes. Plan to spend **at least half your time** on the submission video, if not more. A brilliant project with a bad video loses to a decent project with a great video.

In this guide

- [1. What to build](#)
- [2. Making a video](#)
- [3. Submitting your project](#)

Part 1

What to build

Build something interesting, original, and good

Before you think about videos or social posts, start here: the project itself has to be genuinely compelling. Judges are looking for submissions that are **creative, original, and well-executed**. A polished video of a boring idea won't win.

We're particularly excited by projects that **push the limits** of what ElevenLabs and the week's sponsor technology can do. Don't just use the APIs at their most basic level. Dig into the advanced features, combine them in unexpected ways, and build something that makes people rethink what's possible.

Go beyond the tutorial

Every API has a getting-started example. Don't submit that. Explore the docs, find features most people overlook, and build something the API creators themselves would be impressed by.

Combine tools creatively

The most memorable projects chain multiple APIs together in ways nobody expected. The weirder the combination, the more memorable the demo.

Make it real

Toy demos are forgettable. Build something you or someone else would actually use. If your project solves a real problem for a real audience, it shows.

Picking a project that goes viral

Virality isn't random. Projects that spread tend to share a few traits:

Solve a real pain point

The best demos make people think “I need this.” Pick a problem your audience already complains about (email overload, language barriers, tedious editing) and show it vanishing in 30 seconds.

Be extremely visual

Even if your project is deeply technical, spend time thinking about how to demonstrate the outcome in the real world. Don't just show a terminal. Show what happens when a real person uses it. If people can see the magic, they'll share it.

Surprise people

The most shared tech demos have a “wait, that's possible?” moment. Push the boundary of what the APIs can do. Combine tools in unexpected ways. Make the viewer's jaw drop.

Ride the moment

If there's a trending topic, meme, or cultural event during the hackathon week, build something that ties into it.

Part 2

Making a video

The video is a very important part of your submission. It's the first thing judges watch, and they'll form an opinion before they ever open your project or read your description. A strong video doesn't just show what you built, it **sells the idea**. Think of it as a pitch: you have under 90 seconds to make someone care about your project. If the video is compelling, judges will want to dig deeper. If it's not, they'll move on.

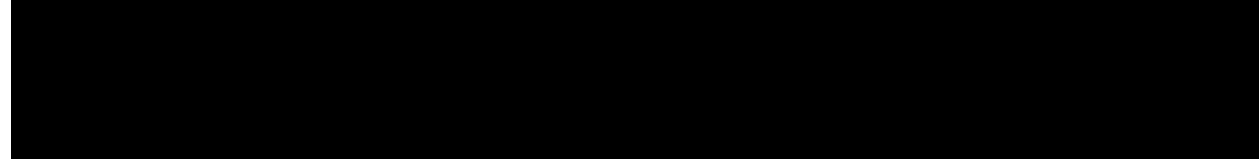
The 5-second rule

You have roughly five seconds before someone scrolls past your video. In that window you need to communicate **exactly what your project does** in a single sentence. Not your tech stack, not a greeting. The outcome.

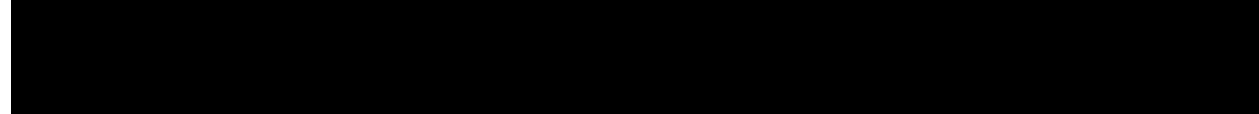
Good openers look like this:

"I built an AI that turns any podcast into an animated short."
"This app reads your codebase and writes your docs for you."
"Watch me clone any voice in real time with one click."

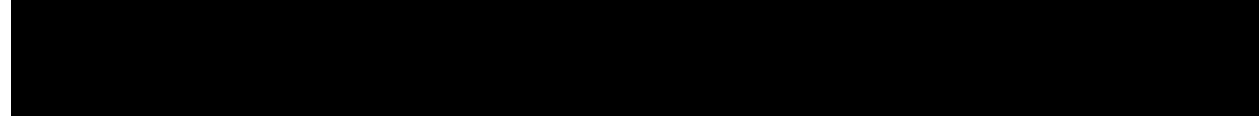
Here's a real example of a submission that nails the hook. Clear value proposition in the first few seconds, visual demo immediately after:



Watch an example of a good viral video



Choosing your hook

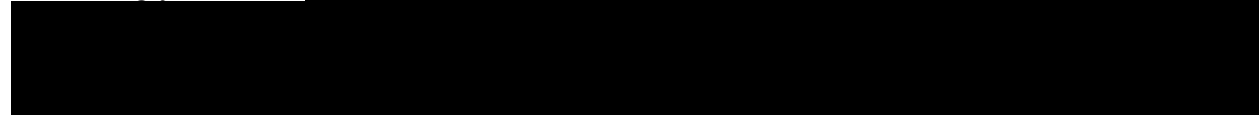


Your hook is the first 3-5 seconds of your video. It determines whether someone watches the rest or keeps scrolling. Three patterns that work:

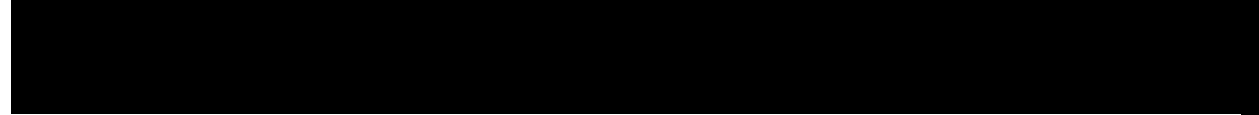


1. **Lead with the outcome.** Show the finished product first, then explain how you built it. "Here's a voice-cloned podcast in 4 languages. Let me show you how."
2. **Make a bold claim.** "I replaced my entire customer support team with one API call."
3. **Start with the "wow" moment.** If your project has a dramatic before/after or a single jaw-dropping interaction, put that at the very beginning. Context can come after.

Recording your demo



Keep it short



60-90 seconds is the sweet spot. Under 60 seconds is even better for social media reach. Cut ruthlessly. Every second should earn its place.



Script it (loosely)

Write 3-5 bullet points, not a word-for-word script. You want to sound natural, not robotic. Practice once or twice, then hit record.

Show, don't tell

Spend 80% of your video showing the product in action. Minimize slides, talking heads, and text screens.

The demo is the content.

Take it outside

The best demos show the tech working in the real world, not just on your laptop at home. Film yourself using it on the street, in a coffee shop, with friends, or in a real scenario where it solves an actual problem. It's more compelling and way more shareable.

Mention ElevenLabs and the partner

Make sure your video includes a clear mention of how you used ElevenLabs and the week's sponsor technology. Judges are looking for creative, meaningful integration, not just a logo flash. Show the API call, the generated audio, the workflow.

Use good audio

Viewers will tolerate mediocre video but bad audio kills engagement instantly. Use a decent microphone, record in a quiet room, or use ElevenLabs to generate a clean voiceover.

Record at 1080p or higher

Social platforms compress video heavily. Starting at higher resolution ensures your final output still looks sharp after upload.

Editing with CapCut

You don't need professional editing software. CapCut is free, works on desktop and mobile, and has everything you need to turn a raw screen recording into a polished submission.

Adding captions in CapCut

1. Import your video into a new CapCut project.
2. Tap **Text** in the bottom toolbar, then select **Auto captions**.
3. Choose your language and hit **Generate**. CapCut will transcribe your audio and place timed captions on the timeline.
4. Pick a caption style. Bold, centered styles with a dark background work best for short-form video. Adjust font size so it's readable on mobile.
5. Review the transcript for errors, trim any dead air, and export at 1080p.

Why captions matter: most social media video is watched on mute. Captions make your demo watchable everywhere: in a meeting, on a commute, at 2 AM with the sound off. They also boost engagement and watch time on every platform.

Set the mood with music

The right background track turns a screen recording into a story. A fast, upbeat track says “this is exciting.” A minimal, atmospheric beat says “this is elegant.” Pick a vibe that matches your project.

Generate your own soundtrack

You can create background music in seconds with [ElevenLabs Music](#). Describe the mood you want (“upbeat tech demo, synth, 90 bpm”) and drop the generated track under your video in CapCut.

Keep the music subtle. It should support your voiceover, not compete with it. Drop the volume to around 15-20% so the viewer focuses on your words.

Part 3

Submitting your project

Writing your description

The description in the submission form is what judges read alongside your video. Keep it concise. Cover three things:

1. **What you built** - one sentence on the product and the problem it solves.
2. **How you used the tech**- mention ElevenLabs and the week's partner specifically. Which APIs, features, or workflows did you use?
3. **What makes it special** - the creative twist, the surprising result, or the real-world impact.

Don't repeat your video script word-for-word. The description should complement it. Add context a judge can skim in 10 seconds.

Uploading a cover image

When you submit, you can upload a cover image for your project. This image is what people see when browsing submissions and voting for the **Most Popular** award. A good cover image makes your project stand out in the gallery. Without one, your submission blends into the background and is far less likely to get clicks or votes.

Make it count

Use a clean screenshot of your project in action, a stylized graphic, or a frame from your video that captures the “wow” moment. Avoid generic stock images or blank placeholders.

Think thumbnail

The image displays at card size. Bold visuals and readable text work best. Small details and tiny fonts will be lost. If your project has a UI, a full-screen capture of the most impressive view is usually the best choice.

Posting for maximum reach

You earn **+50 points per platform** (X, LinkedIn, Instagram, TikTok). Posting on all four gets you **+200 points**, nearly as much as winning a placement prize. Post on as many as you can. A few platform-specific tips:

X (Twitter)

Lead with the one-liner hook as your tweet text. Upload the video natively (don't just paste a YouTube link). Tag @elevenlabsio and the partner. Use #ElevenHacks.

LinkedIn

Frame it as a story: "This week I built X in Y hours for #ElevenHacks. Here's what I learned." LinkedIn rewards text + native video posts. Keep the text under 200 words.

Instagram Reels

Vertical format (9:16) performs best. Re-export your demo cropped for mobile. Captions are essential here since most Reels autoplay muted.

TikTok

Same vertical format as Reels. TikTok's algorithm favours high watch-through rates, so front-load the most impressive part of your demo.

Submission checklist

- Spent at least half your time on the video, not just the code
- One-sentence value prop in the first 5 seconds
- Demo is under 90 seconds
- Captions added for muted viewing
- Background music to set the mood
- Posted on as many social platforms as possible (+50 pts each)
- Clear description in the submission form
- Repo link and/or live demo URL included
- Tagged @elevenlabs and the partner brand